



University center Abdelhafid Boussouf - Mila
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E-Learning unit

English - level 1

– Lesson 8 – English Articles

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Institut	Département	Année	Spécialité
-Lettres et Langues étrangères	- Français	-Français	Licence 1
-Sciences et Techniques	-MI- ST	-MI- ST	Licence 1
-Sciences Economique	-SE	-Toutes les spécialités	Licence 1

Objectives of lesson 8

- i. To make students aware of the existence and role and significance of articles.
- ii. To enable students to use articles appropriately.

1. Definition:

An article is a word used to modify a noun, which is a person, place, object, or idea.

a. Definite Article: The

The article **the** is a determiner in a sentence when placed before a noun or a noun phrase. It is called a definite article as it points to a particular person or thing being mentioned in the sentence. It can be used before a singular or a plural noun, and before a countable and an uncountable noun. Using the word 'the' as a determiner increases the exactness of the subject in a sentence.

Example:

He watched a movie. The movie was about the death of a ghost.

(The movie mentioned in the second sentence is clear as it refers to the movie he watched.)

Uses:

1. When there is only one such person, place or thing:

** the Pope, the President of the United States, the North Pole, the earth, the sky.

2. Before names of famous buildings, etc:

** *the* Eiffel Tower, *the* Great Wall of China

3. Before a singular noun that refers to a whole class or group of people or things:

** *the* middle class, *the* homeless, *the* Canadians, *the* Hindus.

4. Before the special names of rivers, seas, oceans, mountain ranges, group of islands:

** *the* Nile, *the* Dead Sea, *the* Pacific Ocean, *the* Himalayas.

5. Before certain organizations, political parties, and countries:

** the United Nations, the Republican Party,

6. Before nouns such as places which we know of:

** *We arrived early at the ferry terminal for our trip to the island.*

**** We went to the cinema, after which we went to the stadium for a football match.**

7. Before abbreviations and initials of countries:

**** the BBC (the British Broadcasting Corporation), the EEC (the European Economic Community)**

b. Indefinite Article: a, an

The indefinite articles **a** and **an** are used before a singular countable noun which is unspecified, that is a noun that does not refer to a specific person, animal or thing and has not been mentioned before. The indefinite articles are not used before a plural noun or an uncountable noun.

Examples:

I want to buy a table.

(The use of “a” here indicates no special preference for a type of table or a specific table in mind to buy)

Uses:

- 1. To refer to a person or a thing that you are mentioning for the first time in a conversation or a piece of writing.**

**** A man was seen driving away in a black car.**

- 2. To refer to a person or a thing which you do not want to be specific about.**

**** I stopped off at a shop to buy a newspaper.**

- 3. To refer to a person or a thing which you cannot be more specific about because there is not enough information.**

**** A man called to see you this afternoon.**

**** There was a telephone call for you a minute ago.**

- 4. In definitions.**

**** An octopus is a sea creature with eight tentacles.**

- 5. When you refer to a person's profession.**

**** Her father is a dentist and her mother is a teacher**

c. Zero Article

Articles are not always necessary. A noun can be correctly used in a sentence without a definite article or indefinite article preceding it. In such a case, the term **zero article** is used.

Zero articles for:

- 1. For general statements:**

**** Pigs are farm animals.**

- 2. Before plural countable nouns:**

**** He bought red plastic roses for her.**

- 3. No article is required before uncountable nouns.**

**** It is said that money cannot buy happiness.**

- 4. Before abstract nouns used in a general sense:**

5. Before proper nouns:

****** *He is a fan of Michael Jackson.*

6. Before names of materials:

****** *Gold is found in Australia.*

Time for Practice:

Fill in the blank with the appropriate article

1. on our trip, we visited.....lake victoria
2. Have you ever visited.....United Kingdom?
3. Love iswonderful thing.
4. Rabbits are.....small wild furry animals with long ears.
5. New York is in.....United States of America.
6. Ariane has got.....German car.

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